

KEY DEVELOPMENT

PIKES AND MUSKETS

In the 16th and 17th centuries, Europe was a continent almost constantly at war. Over the course of these decades of conflict, European armies experimented with fighting methods that bestowed new importance on infantry armed with pikes and firearms.

Medieval European foot soldiers were often effective but were generally seen as being of low repute. In the early 16th century, however, the Renaissance rediscovery of the military techniques of Ancient Greece and Rome – the Greek phalanx and the Roman legion – suddenly made infantry fashionable. The most admired fighting men of 16th-century Europe, such as the German *Landesknecchte* and the Spanish *tercios*, fought on foot, utilizing massed bodies of pikemen. This technique had been pioneered by the Swiss, but now firearms were added to the formations: although some foot soldiers continued to use the bow, the matchlock arquebus overtook it as the key infantry missile weapon during the Italian Wars (1494–1559). The arquebus was neither accurate nor powerful, but it could weaken an enemy pike

square or help hold off a cavalry charge. Mobile field cannon – of bronze and firing iron shot – also began to make their mark on the battlefield.

INFANTRY DISCIPLINE

When they could afford it, 16th-century infantry wore extensive plate armour for protection against arquebus fire, as well as against pikes, swords, and halberds. But during the second half of the 16th century, the matchlock musket came into use. A heavier weapon that required a forked rest to aim, the musket could penetrate most plate armour at moderate range, and the proportion of foot soldiers carrying them gradually increased. The importance of discipline in the effectiveness of



▲ MUSKETEER'S KIT

Musket soldiers in the English Civil Wars (1642–51) rarely wore armour. The red coat was the uniform of men of Parliament's New Model Army.

▼ BATTLE OF MARIGNANO

The tomb of King François I of France is decorated with this image of his victory at Marignano in 1515. In it, François leads his knights in a charge with couched lance against Swiss pikemen backed by field artillery.

“Advanced within musket shot of the enemy, the foot on both sides began to give fire”

FUTURE KING OF ENGLAND, JAMES II, DESCRIBING THE BATTLE OF EDGEHILL, 1642

